

CINDERALLA

Junko Mizuno

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The Movement Behind the Manga

● Coined by Takashi Murakami

Arose from post-war Japan's consumer culture, manga and anime — a society literally 'flattened' by mass media, advertising and pop imagery.

● Two-Dimensional Aesthetic

Eliminates depth, shading and perspective. Bold outlines + flat colour fills — directly descended from Edo-period ukiyo-e woodblock printing.

● High Art / Low Culture Collapse

Deliberately erases the boundary between fine art and commercial pop imagery — manga panels, merchandise, idol posters all treated as equally valid.

● Cultural & Social Critique

The flatness is also ideological — a critique of post-atomic Japan's infantilised consumer society. 'Cute' as both symptom and weapon.

VISUAL HALLMARKS

- Flat, unmodulated single-colour fills
- Uniform bold black outlines
- No cast shadows or perspective
- Kawaii (cute) character proportions
- Grotesque content in cute packaging
- Pattern fills replace backgrounds
- Manga panel grammar & gutters
- SFX lettering as graphic element

Junko Mizuno's Cinderella

Junko Mizuno

Self-taught Tokyo manga artist. Her 'Gothic kawaii' style — childlike sweetness fused with horror, erotica and dark humour — became internationally influential. Worked alone, no assistants. Described her process as compulsive.

Publication History

First published in Japan (Koushinsya, 2000). English edition: Viz Media (2002). Reached a 4th edition by 2006. Translated into French, Portuguese and Spanish. Original art exhibited at Gallery Nucleus, California.

Why Cinderella?

Mizuno was pressured by her publisher to adapt a pre-existing fairy tale to prove her storytelling ability. She was initially resistant. The choice of Cinderella — the most passive fairy-tale heroine — was deliberate subversion.

Superflat Context

Published the same year as Murakami's Superflat manifesto. Mizuno's work was cited as exemplary of the movement's core tension: kawaii surface concealing grotesque content. She extended it into feminist territory.

The Full Plot of Mizuno's Cinderalla

ACT I

A Happy Life

Cinderalla works joyfully as waitress in her father's famous yakitori restaurant — customers love her. One day her father collapses; she rushes to hospital. He has eaten himself into an early death.

ACT II

Zombies in the House

Father rises from the dead and falls in love with Caroline — a ceaselessly hungry zombie with a strip-club past. Now Cinderalla manages a chaotic zombie household: making bras, keeping Aki from stripping at the restaurant, and caring for everyone.

ACT III

The Fairy

Twin children catch a tiny starving fairy to dissect. Cinderalla intervenes furiously, rescues it, and takes it home. The fairy, grateful and somewhat alcoholic, stays. Cinderalla discovers a flyer: the zombie Prince is performing. Zombies only. She works part-time for months saving every yen.

ACT IV

The Glass Eyeball

The fairy transforms Cinderalla into a zombie. At the show the Prince — on a permanent IV drip — literally falls from the ceiling onto her. They spend the night together. Fleeing at dawn, she trips and her right EYE rolls out. The Prince: 'I will marry the zombie whose eye fits.'

END

Happily Ever After (Sort Of)

The eye fits. They marry, become celebrities. Cinderalla grows giant strawberries from Papa's sauce and opens a new restaurant. The fairy appears on TV. The stepsisters get their own happy endings. Everyone is forgiven — echoing Perrault's original kind ending.

KEY CHARACTERS

Who Inhabits Mizuno's Zombie Fairy Tale?

Cinderalla

Protagonist

Capable, independent, agentic. Works for her own ticket, rescues the fairy, forgives all. Never a passive victim — her kawaii look conceals real toughness. Teal long hair, flower-print clothes.

The Prince

Love Interest

Sickly zombie pop star on a permanent IV drip. Pathetically subverted — no white horse, no heroic rescue. Falls off the ceiling by accident. Played entirely for comic irony.

Caroline

Stepmother

Never-ending appetite, formerly a stripper. Grotesque, funny, oddly warm. Represents consumer excess made flesh. Not classically 'evil' — more chaotically self-absorbed.

The Fairy

Fairy Godmother

Tiny, starving, alcoholic, morally ambiguous. Grants Cinderalla's wish to become a zombie then largely disappears. A parody of the all-knowing magical helper. Rescued from vivisection by red-haired twins.

Papa

Father

Dies from overeating, rises as a zombie, falls in love with Caroline. Still kind throughout. His legendary yakitori sauce is the book's central MacGuffin — it grows giant strawberries, it drives the economy.

Aki & Akko

Stepsisters

Scattered, demanding, but not purely evil. Red-haired with matching outfits. Akko chases foreign celebrities; Aki nearly strips at the restaurant. Both get happy endings — Mizuno follows Perrault's forgiving version.

The Restaurant: Cinderella at Work



Panel Grid

Three-tier layout: wide top panel (establishing shot of customers) → two mid panels (action + Papa) → two bottom panels (Cinderella + speech). Classic shōjo rhythm: spectacle then intimacy.

Colour as Zone

Each panel has a distinct flat background fill — warm cream, pale pink, white. No tones blend across panel borders. Colour marks zone, not light. Pure Superflat doctrine from page one.

SFX Typography

'ARFF!' in the lower-left is drawn as a visual element — thick black-outlined letters with a dynamic tilt, functioning as both sound and graphic shape. SFX as composition.

Kawaii Proportions

Characters have oversized heads (~40% of body height), enormous eyes with multiple catchlights, tiny noses and mouths. Deliberately non-anatomical — expressiveness over realism.

Outfit as Character Code

Cinderella wears a flower-print halter; customers have dots and stars. Mizuno uses clothing pattern as shorthand identity — readable instantly without realistic detail.

Narrative Function

The warm orange palette and 'I just love working!' establish contentment that will be systematically destroyed. This is the 'before' the story tears apart — done in six panels.

'Daddy!!' — Crisis & Hospital Spread



Double-Page Tonal Shift

Left page: warm orange/brown (restaurant, everyday life). Right page: cold grey-white-yellow (hospital, shock). A full palette switch across the gutter — Mizuno uses colour temperature as emotional language.

'DADDY!!' Splash Panel

The central vertical panel breaks the grid entirely — white radial burst lines, full-bleed text. A shōnen-style impact moment inserted into a shōjo book. The genre mash is deliberate and jarring.

Background Storytelling

Left page backgrounds are intricate and warm: decorative wallpaper, caged ornaments, pots on shelves. Right page backgrounds strip back to bare white. Busyness = safety; emptiness = crisis.

The 'I'm Sorry' Panel

The final small panel — muted yellow, the doctor's face with simple 'I'm sorry' — is tiny after the giant DADDY!! splash. Scale contrast for emotional devastation. Minimalism at the moment of maximum pain.

The Graveyard — Zombie World



Dominant Violet Palette

The graveyard world is entirely violet/purple — a single hue defines this realm. Colour = world-building. Mizuno never uses atmospheric rendering; she uses hue fields to signal location and mood.

'AIEEEE' as Graphic Cascade

The scream text runs diagonally across the right-page splash in decreasing scale, becoming part of the composition itself. Letters as sound-wave, as movement, as visual rhythm. Text fully integrated into image.

Flat Crowd Composition

The graveyard crowd on the right page is packed in a single flat plane — no depth, no overlapping in perspective. Heads pop up like a pattern repeat. Superflat's rejection of illusionistic space is total here.

Candlelight as Flat Shape

The candle flame Cinderella holds is drawn as a solid red teardrop — no flicker, no glow, no shadow cast. Fire as flat graphic symbol. This is the visual argument of the whole book condensed into one detail.

Cross / Skull Motif

Grave markers are abstracted into decorative shapes — crosses, wheels, skulls with pattern fills. Horror iconography made ornamental. The grotesque is aestheticised into kawaii-gothic design.

The Fairy Kidnapped — Action Sequence



Red Action Palette

The kidnap scene explodes into red-orange — an abrupt break from the pink/purple domestic world. Mizuno uses palette shift as a scene-change cut: warm danger vs. cool domesticity.

Motion & Impact Devices

'FWISH' lettering + radial net impact panel (top-left) uses full shōnen action grammar: impact burst, motion lines, SFX at strike point. A violence panel made cute by the kawaii characters inside it.

Left-Right Page Contrast

Left page: kinetic red chaos. Right page: Cinderalla in cool teal hearing the screams, then stepping outside to investigate. The page turn performs the narrative transition — action / reaction.

Background Depth Trick

Right-page panel 2 shows the strawberry cottage from outside — a rare establishing shot with a horizon line. Yet even here: flat colour fills, decorative scale-pattern rooftiles, no atmospheric perspective.

'Uh Oh' Economy

Final panel — just Cinderalla's teal face, half in shadow, with 'UH OH.' This is pure comics economy: no background, no body, just face and two words. The reader fills in the rest.

Cinderella Rescues the Fairy



Moral Clarity Through Colour

Cinderella = teal/mint (cool, trustworthy). The twins = red (danger, aggression). The fairy = pink (vulnerable). Mizuno's colour coding is consistent — readers know who to trust from hue alone.

The Dissection Table Panel

Top-left: the fairy pinned on a lab table with syringes, potions, a dissected pink rabbit. Horror content rendered in exactly the same cute line style as a tea party. The aesthetic register never changes. The grotesque is normalised by style.

'STOP IT! THIS IS HORRIBLE!!'

The speech bubble breaks panel frame — text runs out of its box, past the panel border. Formal transgression mirrors emotional transgression. Cinderella's outrage literally exceeds the panel's ability to contain it.

'FWINCH' vs. 'FWUD'

The SFX for the tail-whip punishment (FWUD, FWINCH) are drawn as kinetic graphic shapes — thick outlined letters tilted at action angles. Sound as image, image as story. This is what separates Mizuno from prose adaptation.

Final Panel: Quiet Judgement

The last panel is wide and calm — Cinderella standing in soft teal, looking away, simply saying 'More into their bodies than their own children.' Dark social commentary delivered as flat observation. The palette cools; the violence is over.

Classic Cinderella vs. Mizuno's Version

Element	Classic / Disney Version	Mizuno's Cinderalla
Setting	Medieval kingdom, ballroom	Post-industrial Japan — yakitori restaurants, neon graveyards
Protagonist	Passive, virtuous, waiting to be rescued	Active waitress who earns her own ticket through part-time work
Prince	Handsome romantic saviour on white horse	Sickly zombie pop star on a permanent IV drip; falls on her by accident
Fairy Godmother	All-powerful benevolent magical figure	Tiny, starving, alcoholic — rescued by Cinderalla, not the other way around
Transformation	Beautiful gown & glass slipper	Zombie body — physical decay as liberation, not beautification
The Slipper	Glass slipper lost at midnight	Eyeball rolls out at dawn — bodily horror as romantic identification
Stepmother / Sisters	Pure villains	Comic, grotesque, ultimately forgiven — echoes Perrault's kinder original
Ending	Escape into romantic marriage	Celebrity, business success, forgiveness — community, not just a couple

Visual Language Across the Pages

Line Art

Inking Style

Uniform line weight throughout — no variation for depth or tactile surface. Pure manga technique. Derived from Edo-period woodblock, where the carved line has the same weight everywhere.

Colour

Flat Spot Colour Fills

Every region: one flat tone, no shading, no gradient, no reflected light. Colour as zone marker, not illusion. Visible in every page analysed — the graveyard purple, the restaurant orange, Cinderalla's teal.

Composition

Manga Panel Grammar

Gutter space, bleed panels, irregular tier heights. Wide panels = spectacle (DADDY!! splash). Tight panels = intimacy or tension (the doctor's 'I'm sorry'). Grid as narrative pacing tool.

Character

Kawaii-Grotesque

Oversized eyes, tiny mouths, exaggerated body proportions — but the bodies are sexualised and the scenes are violent. The cute style absorbs horror without flinching. This is Mizuno's central formal argument.

Typography

SFX as Image

AIEEEE, FWISH, FWUD, ARFF — each drawn as a unique graphic object with its own angle, outline weight and spatial relationship to the action. In Mizuno's pages, you cannot separate text from image.

Space

Flat Backgrounds

Where Western comics render environment, Mizuno deploys pattern fills and single-colour fields. The roof tile scales, the graveyard dots, the flower wallpaper — all surface decoration, no perspective, no depth.

What is Cinderalla Really About?

Consumerism & Appetite

Food is the engine: it kills Papa, defines Caroline, drives the sauce brand, grows the giant strawberries. The fairy tale's magical economy is rewritten as a consumer economy. Desire = appetite = grotesque.

Body & Transformation

Classic fairy tale: transformation = beautification. Mizuno: transformation = zombification — bodily decay as liberation. The glass slipper becomes a detached eye. The body is comic material, not sacred vessel.

Female Agency

Cinderalla earns her own concert ticket, rescues the fairy, runs the restaurant, forgives the stepsisters, builds a post-marriage business. She is never a victim waiting. Her agency is page-one consistent.

Kawaii as Armour

The grotesque — dissection, death, dismemberment, sexuality — survives inside a kawaii visual register. The cuteness is not naivety. It is a frame that makes horror sayable. This is the book's core visual argument.

Dark Comedy & Irony

Described as 'Powerpuff Girls on acid' and 'Hello Kitty meets Chucky.' The Greenwood Encyclopedia notes the dark humour. The tone is comedy of bodily excess and social absurdity, not horror.

The Fairy Tale Market

Mizuno was pressured to adapt a pre-existing story for commercial viability — and she made a book about navigating a world of consumer spectacle. The meta-irony is fully intentional.

Feminist, Postcolonial & Cultural Readings

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Mizuno's Cinderella doesn't wait to be saved. She navigates a world of grotesque desire and consumer spectacle entirely on her own terms — her kawaii 'flatness' is not passivity. It is armour.

— Thematic interpretation via Superflat feminist art criticism

Gender & Agency

Cinderella is sexual subject, not object. She earns her ticket, rescues the fairy, builds her business. Postfeminist consciousness runs through the entire work — visible in every plot beat.

Consumer Culture Critique

The fairy-tale's magic economy is rewritten as commerce. Transformation costs money. The concert needs a ticket. The sauce is a brand. The glass slipper is a product. Consumer capitalism as fairy-tale logic.

Postcolonial Hybridity

A Western fairy tale, drawn in Japanese manga tradition, published for an American market. The work embodies the same cultural hybridity that Superflat was born from — Japan's post-war absorption and subversion of Western pop forms.

Critical Response & Cultural Impact

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A sarcastic, bizarre and dark humour version of Cinderella — like an episode of The Powerpuff Girls written and directed by Coffin Joe.

Folha de S.Paulo — Brazil

“

A union of Hello Kitty and Chucky.

Público — Spain

“

Cinderella contains irony and dark humour. Its ending — in which Cinderella forgives her stepsisters — is reminiscent of Perrault's original version.

Greenwood Encyclopedia of Folktales & Fairy Tales

“

Junko Mizuno's work possesses a postfeminist consciousness. The psychedelic tone is enhanced by the artist's playful, grotesque-cute colour illustrations.

Critical Reception / Goodreads

CONCLUSION

What Cinderalla Tells Us

Mizuno's Cinderalla is not a retelling — it is a graphic art manifesto disguised as a fairy tale.

The Superflat aesthetic — flat fill, bold line, kawaii proportions — is not decoration. It is the argument. The pages prove it.

Every fairy-tale trope is subverted: passive heroine, rescuing prince, evil stepmother, magical transformation, glass slipper.

Close reading the actual pages reveals sophisticated control of colour, panel scale, SFX typography and character design — all in service of a feminist and critical project.

Mizuno's work sits exactly where Superflat always meant to live: between cute and disturbing, between pop culture and fine art, between tradition and transgression.